

1. CAST

Position	People	Approx. wage
Colonel David Hale — Lead	1	\$75k–\$300k
Maya Reyes	1	\$20k–\$75k
Daniel Kim	1	\$15k–\$50k
Major/Officer	2–3	\$8k–\$25k each
Engineers / Scientists	3–5	\$3k–\$12k each
Military personnel / operators	10–20	\$250–\$1,000/day
Technicians	5–10	\$250–\$1,000/day
Civilians	15–30	\$150–\$500/day
Background / extras	50–150+	\$150–\$500/day

Core speaking cast: roughly 15–25 people
Total people appearing on camera: potentially 100–200+, depending on how much is done with VFX.

2. DIRECTING / PRODUCING

Position	People	Approx. wage
Director	1	\$75k–\$300k
Producer	1–2	\$50k–\$150k each
Executive Producer	1–3	\$25k–\$150k+
Line Producer	1	\$40k–\$100k
Production Manager	1	\$25k–\$60k
1st Assistant Director	1	\$25k–\$50k
2nd Assistant Director	1	\$15k–\$30k
Script Supervisor	1	\$15k–\$30k
Production Coordinator	1–2	\$10k–\$25k each

Department: ~10–15 people

3. WRITING / STORY

Position	People	Approx. wage
Screenwriter	1–2	\$30k–\$150k+
Military/technical consultant	1–3	\$5k–\$30k each
AI/technology consultant	1–2	\$5k–\$25k each
Script editor / story consultant	1	\$5k–\$20k

For this movie, I would strongly recommend having at least one military consultant and one technology/AI consultant.

4. CAMERA DEPARTMENT

Position	People	Approx. wage
Director of Photography	1	\$50k–\$150k
Camera Operator	1–2	\$20k–\$50k each
1st AC / Focus Puller	1	\$15k–\$35k
2nd AC	1	\$10k–\$25k
Digital Imaging Technician	1	\$15k–\$35k
Steadicam Operator	1	\$10k–\$25k
Drone/Aerial Camera Operator	1–2	\$5k–\$20k each

Department: ~7–10 people

5. LIGHTING / ELECTRICAL

Position	People	Approx. wage
Gaffer	1	\$25k–\$60k
Best Boy Electric	1	\$15k–\$30k
Electricians	4–8	\$8k–\$20k each
Lighting technicians	2–4	\$8k–\$20k each

Department: ~8–14 people

6. GRIP

Position	People	Approx. wage
Key Grip	1	\$25k–\$50k
Best Boy Grip	1	\$15k–\$30k
Grips	4–8	\$8k–\$20k each
Rigging Grip	1–2	\$10k–\$25k each

Department: ~7–12 people

7. PRODUCTION DESIGN

This movie needs a large production-design department because the Black Site, Obsidian Facility, command center, repair facility, hangars, AI chamber, military interiors, etc. all need to feel like one believable world.

Position	People	Approx. wage
Production Designer	1	\$40k–\$100k
Art Director	1	\$20k–\$50k
Set Designer	1–2	\$10k–\$30k each
Set Decorator	1	\$15k–\$35k
Prop Master	1	\$15k–\$35k
Props crew	4–8	\$5k–\$15k each

Construction Coordinator	1	\$15k–\$35k
Set builders	8–20	\$5k–\$20k each
Scenic artists	2–5	\$5k–\$15k each
Department: ~20–40 people		

8. COSTUME / MAKEUP

Position	People	Approx. wage
Costume Designer	1	\$20k–\$50k
Costume Supervisor	1	\$10k–\$25k
Wardrobe crew	2–4	\$5k–\$15k each
Makeup Department Head	1	\$15k–\$35k
Makeup Artists	2–4	\$5k–\$15k each
Hair Department	1–2	\$5k–\$15k each
Department: ~8–13 people		

9. SOUND

This movie needs strong sound because the autonomous machines, aircraft, weapons, command center, alarms and battlefield should feel massive.

Position	People	Approx. wage
Production Sound Mixer	1	\$20k–\$40k
Boom Operator	1	\$10k–\$20k
Sound Utility	1	\$8k–\$15k
Sound Designer	1–2	\$20k–\$60k each
Re-recording Mixer	1–2	\$15k–\$40k each
Foley Artist	1–2	\$10k–\$25k each
Department: ~7–10 people		

10. ACTION / MILITARY

This is one of the most important departments for this movie.

Position	People	Approx. wage
Stunt Coordinator	1	\$20k–\$50k
Stunt Performers	8–20	\$3k–\$15k each
Military Technical Advisor	1–3	\$5k–\$30k each
Tactical Advisor	1	\$5k–\$20k
Armorer / Weapons Coordinator	1–2	\$5k–\$20k each
Tactical performers	10–30	\$250–\$750/day

Because most of the "soldiers" in this movie are autonomous machines, you can save a significant amount compared with a conventional human-soldier war movie.

11. VISUAL EFFECTS — VERY IMPORTANT

This is where **Obsidian Protocol** becomes expensive.

You have:

Autonomous ground armies
Hundreds/thousands of machines
Warden aircraft
Naval battles
Black Site
Global warfare
Explosions
Destroyed cities
Holographic maps
AI systems
Nullpoint
Satellite systems
Space shots
Large-scale battlefield environments

I'd use a combination of practical sets + digital environments + CGI units.

Position	People	Approx. wage
VFX Supervisor	1	\$50k–\$150k
VFX Producer	1	\$30k–\$75k
VFX Coordinator	1–2	\$10k–\$25k each
VFX Artists	20–60+	\$10k–\$50k each
3D Modelers	5–15	\$10k–\$40k each
Animators	5–20	\$10k–\$40k each
FX Artists	5–15	\$10k–\$40k each
Compositors	5–15	\$10k–\$40k each
Environment Artists	5–15	\$10k–\$40k each
Technical Artists	2–6	\$15k–\$50k each

VFX team: roughly **40–100+ people**

They don't all need to be employed for the entire production.

12. POST-PRODUCTION

Position	People	Approx. wage
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Editor	1	\$40k–\$100k
Assistant Editors	2–3	\$10k–\$30k each
Colorist	1	\$15k–\$40k
Composer	1	\$20k–\$75k
Music Editor	1	\$10k–\$25k
Sound Designer	1–2	\$20k–\$60k each
ADR team	2–5	\$5k–\$20k
VFX team	40–100+	varies
Titles / Graphics	2–5	\$5k–\$20k each
Post Producer	1	\$20k–\$50k

13. PRODUCTION OFFICE / SUPPORT

Position	People
Production Assistants	10–20
Locations Manager	1–2
Location Assistants	2–5
Transportation Captain	1
Drivers	5–15
Catering	5–10
Craft Services	2–5
Safety Coordinator	1
Set Medic	1–2
Security	4–10
Payroll / Accounting	2–4
Legal	1–3

TOTAL PEOPLE

For the movie I would plan around:

Core production team

~80–120 people

Full physical production

~150–250 people

Including VFX/post-production

~200–350+ people

You don't pay all 300 people for the same amount of time. Departments come in and out throughout development, pre-production, filming, VFX and post.

ROUGH MOVIE LABOR BUDGET

For a serious independent production:

Production level	Approx. total production budget
Very low budget	\$5M–\$10M
Low/mid budget	\$15M–\$30M
Strong indie	\$30M–\$60M
Studio-quality SF	\$60M–\$100M+
Large studio	\$100M–\$200M+

For **this particular movie**, I would personally target approximately **\$40M–\$75M** if the goal is to make the world, machines and battles look genuinely convincing without trying to compete with a \$200M Hollywood blockbuster.

The biggest money should go toward **VFX, production design, action, cinematography, sound, and the lead cast**—not filling the production with unnecessary personnel.

And because the story is specifically about **autonomous warfare**, you can make the armies enormous on screen without needing thousands of human performers. The audience sees thousands of machines, while the physical production may only need a relatively small number of real actors and practical machines.